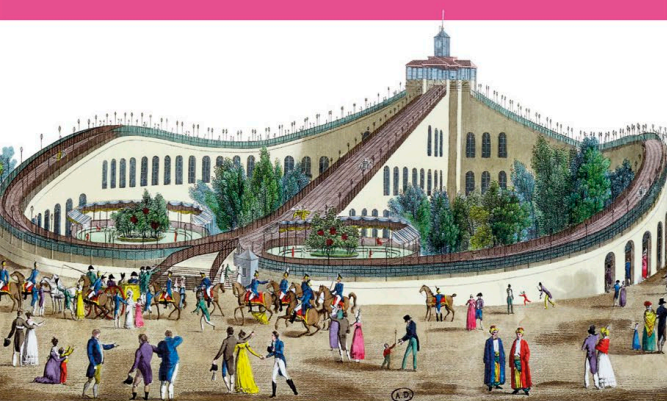


July

8



1817

Roller-coaster

The world's first roller-coaster opened in an amusement park in Paris, France. The *Promenades Aériennes* featured wheeled carts that hurtled down curving tracks at up to 64 kph (40 mph).

Born this day

1593 Artemisia Gentileschi, Italian painter. Among the most successful women painters of the 17th century, she became famous for her bold, colourful, and realistic paintings of women from the Bible.

Girl power

The Spice Girls, an all-female British pop group, released their smash-hit single *Wannabe*. The song won over young fans across the world with its emphasis on strong friendships between women.

1996



1853

Mission to Japan

With a fleet of four ships, US Navy officer Matthew Perry sailed into the harbour of Uraga, Japan, hoping to force the nation to open to US trade after more than 200 years of isolation.



Also on this day

1497 Portuguese explorer Vasco da Gama set sail with a fleet of four ships on the world's first sea voyage from Europe to India.

1775 British colonies in North America signed the Olive Branch Petition in an attempt to avoid war with Great Britain. The petition was rejected by the British king and war followed.

1947 The US military reported the discovery of a mysterious "flying disc" near Roswell, New Mexico, sparking decades of conspiracy theories about alien spacecraft.